

Brilliant cut

Brilliant cuts maximize brilliance. They are also used on coloured stones to deepen their colour, conceal imperfections, and to even out patchy colour. Their facets, cut in a vertical direction from crown to pavilion, are roughly triangular or kite-shaped. The actual outline of the stone can vary from round to oval, to pendeloque, or even freeform, so long as the facets are triangular.



Brilliant round



Brilliant oval



Brilliant round demantoid garnet



Brilliant oval iolite

Cabochon

Gems cut with a flat back and a domed top are called cabochons. The dome itself can be flat, or high in proportion to the outline dimensions of the stone. The high dome is used to emphasize the particular optical properties of certain stones, such as asterism, iridescence, or a cat's-eye effect. When the gem has colour or pattern as part of its basic structure, the dome is usually shallower, in order to show off the colour or pattern to best effect. In terms of their outlines, cabochons can be virtually any shape.



Cabochon



Sodalite oval cabochon

Step cut

Step cuts are used to enhance the colour of a stone, although they generally produce less sparkle as a consequence. These cuts have rectangular facets in broad flat planes that resemble steps. The most widely used step cut is the emerald cut, which was originally designed to preserve valuable emerald rough. This is the preferred cut for brittle stones because it leaves them with no vulnerable sharp corners.



Square cut



Baguette



Emerald cut



Emerald-cut emerald

Mixed cut

Mixed cuts combine brilliant and step-cut facets, optimizing a stone's dimensions and visual properties to enhance the brilliance of a coloured stone, while still emphasizing its colour. The step-cut faces can be on the crown or pavilion. A mixed cut's outline shape can be virtually anything as long as the crown and pavilion display different cuts.



Mixed cut



Cushion cut



Cushion-cut heliodor



Mixed-cut topaz

Fancy cuts

Cuts with unusual outlines and facets are known as fancy cuts. Among these are hearts, free-form shapes with irregular outlines, kites, scissor, and pendeloque cuts, and standard shapes with unusual faceting – for example, where the facets form flat planes to create a chequer-board or zig-zag pattern. Gems cut into elongated ovals with pointed ends exhibit the marquise cut.



Scissor cut



Pendeloque



Marquise cut



Garnet heart



Marquise-cut blue diamond

Carving

In general, carving means the shaping of a piece of gemstone rough into a three-dimensional figure. It is a very skilled lapidary art that can take several forms. These include intaglios, or relief carving, with the figure carved into the gem; cameos, with a figure or scene in relief on a contrasting coloured background; or even full, three-dimensional figures, birds, and animals.



Cameo



Carved coral cameo